

Orthodoxy 201

Let us stand well; let us stand in awe...

- ◆ After the Symbol of Faith (the Creed) has been recited by all, we now hear the words above, that is the Holy Sacrifice which we offer up to God. We are reaching the most *Sacred moment* of The Divine Liturgy. Unfortunately,, the Angelic Powers stand in fear and terror, covering their faces with reverence while at the same time praising the Almighty God.
- ◆ Unfortunately, during this time many are unaware of what is actually happening in this beautiful time because maybe they are distracted and not focusing on what is taking place.
- ◆ *“While the name of peace is often heard, the essence is nowhere to be found. In the ancient times, the homes of the faithful were like churches, but now even the church has become a home, or rather worse than a home. Or in a home one can see orderliness... but there is much noise, great confusion, and there is no difference between this (raucous atmosphere) and a Tavern”.* St. John Chrysostom

The Anaphora

- ◆ Now begins the part of the liturgy called the Eucharistic Canon. It is also called the Anaphora, which means the *lifting-up or elevation*. At this time the gifts of bread and wine which have been offered on the Altar are lifted up to God the Father, and receive Divine Sanctification by the Holy Spirit. Who comes to change them into the Very Body and Very Blood of Jesus Christ.
- ◆ The general form of the Eucharistic canon is that of the Old Testament Passover ritual, now fulfilled and perfected in the new and everlasting Covenant of God with the Person and work of Jesus Christ the Messiah, *“Our Paschal lamb who has been sanctified.”* Thus the Eucharistic Anaphora begins right after the creed
- ◆ The Holy Offering is Christ, the Son of God Who has become the Son of Man in order to offer Himself to His Father for the life of the world. In His own Person, Jesus is perfect peace Offering which alone brings God’s reconciling mercy. This is undoubtedly the meaning of the expression a mercy of peace (which is what follows the Let us stand aright) which has been a source of confusion for people over the years in all-liturgical languages.

- ◆ In addition to being the perfect peace, Jesus is also the only adequate Sacrifice of praise which people can offer to God. There is nothing comparable in men to the graciousness of God. There is nothing with which we can worthily thank and praise the Creator. This is so, even if we would not be sinners. Thus, God Himself provides us with our own most perfect Sacrifice of praise: The Son of God becomes genuinely human so that human persons could have one of their own nature sufficiently adequate to the Holiness and Graciousness of God. Again, this is Christ, the “Sacrifice of praise.”
- ◆ Thus, in Christ, all is fulfilled and accomplished. In Him the entire sacrificial system of the OT, which is itself the image of the universal striving of men to be worthy of God, is fulfilled. All possible offerings are embodied and Perfected in the Offering of Christ on the Cross. HE IS the Offering for peace and reconciliation and forgiveness. HE IS the Sacrifice for supplication, thanksgiving and praise. Through Him alone do men have access to the Father in one Holy Spirit (Ephesians 2:18; John 14).

An offering of peace, a Sacrifice of Praise

- ◆ We must consider carefully what is happening at this moment and beginning to take place; how the Lamb of God is coming to be sacrificed for us, how the precious blood of our Lord is ready to be poured into the holy chalice, how all the heavenly powers are praying now with us.
- ◆ While reflecting now and knowing this and understanding this to the best of our ability we are now able to set the heights of our hearts extremely high as high as if we say...
- ◆ “Let us lift up our hearts” as the Clergy exclaim, with the response “we lift them up to the Lord”, this means now that in doing this we have turned COMPLETELY to the Lord on High!
- ◆ *“My good man what are you doing? When the priest said, ‘let us lift up our hearts’, did you not promise saying, ‘we lift them up to the Lord’? Aren't you afraid, embarrassed, and ashamed to be shown a liar at this most fearful time?”* again the words of St. John Chrysostom

The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, love of God the Father and communion of the Holy Spirit

- ◆ The grace of Christ comes first. In this grace is contained the fullness of the love of God and the communion of the Holy Spirit. The celebrant offers this entire abundant outpouring of the inner life of the Holy Trinity to the People of God. And they in turn respond with the prayer that this “fullness of God” would be with his spirit as well.
- ◆ Then we hear the Eucharistic dialogue continue:
- ◆ *Let us lift up our hearts! We lift them up to the Lord!*

- ✦ We should strive to have our hearts be turned to the Lord at all times day or night and wherever we may find ourselves...especially though during this Sacred Holy hour as we approach to make our offering to God.
- ✦ By heart is meant our entire life, our thinking words and especially our actions we must remember our feelings and our emotions and rightfully put our desires and attitudes in the proper place seeking the Kingdom of God. Remember heaven is the destination and the Eucharist provides us the proper GPS.
- ✦ This is why we are here at this Divine Service – to offer our Eucharistic Offering to the Lord – do we realize this???

Anaphora Cont'd

- ✦ The manner of lifting up oneself to God is through thanksgiving. The word Eucharist in Greek means thanksgiving. The Eucharistic Divine Liturgy is preeminently the action of lifting up one's heart and giving thanks to God for all that He has done for humankind and the world in Christ and the Holy Spirit: creation, salvation and eternal glorification.
- ✦ The original sin of man, the origin of all his trouble, corruption and ultimate death, is his failure to give thanks to God. The restoration of communion with God, and with all creation inH, is through thanksgiving to Christ. Jesus is the Only Man truly grateful, humble, and obedient to God the Father. In Him, as The Only Beloved Son of God and the only perfect Adam, all people can "lift up their hearts and give thanks to the Lord": *"For there is... one mediator between God and men, the Man of Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a ransom for all..."* (Timothy 2:5).
- ✦ For this reason we "give thanks to the Lord"

Proper and Right

- ✦ Various times and in our dialogue we tend to define the *value* or *worth* of something, in English the words "worship" and "worth" have the same root. We worship whatever is of ultimate value to us. Orthodox Christians believe that worship of the One, True and Living God is our highest calling as human beings and gives our lives the true meaning, true purpose and true direction, this is done through true worship, and The Holy Spirit.
- ✦ *Worship is to love God with all our mind, all our heart, all our strength and our soul* (Mark 12:30). Real worship is offering our whole life to God everything that we have and everything that we are – to God!
- ✦ This is why worship in the Orthodox Church is not simply going to church for service, rather it is a way of life a lifestyle of complete and total devotion and surrendering ourselves to God.

- ◆ The more we surrender ourselves to God the more we become Christ-like:
- ◆ more forgiving, more patient, more loving, more compassionate, more grateful, more peaceful, more faithful, more joyful.
- ◆ In the Liturgy we are to be transformed to become like God whom we are worshipping this is called in the Orthodox Church Theosis – God became man, in order for man to be becoming like God/

Anaphora Cont'd

- ◆ “The principal difference between BAS and CHR rests chiefly in the second part of the divine liturgy. The differences are both external and internal. The prayers differ not only in length but also in content, and this is especially true of the holy anaphora” Fr Calivas The Liturgy in Dialogue, 24-9
- ◆ The anaphora of BAS is powerful in its unity of thought theological depth and rich biblical imagery. It contains a grand litany of titles and attributes of the three persons of the Holy Trinity and their particular role and mode of being.
- ◆ “The anaphora of CHR by contrast is shorter and less rhetorical. It is characterized by its simplicity, directness, and clarity. It is also marked by the absence of literal biblical passages, which is typical of the more primitive forms of liturgical prayer.” ibid

Personal Reflection

- ◆ *Are we grateful to God for his love?*
- ◆ *Do we thank him throughout our lives for the benefits we have received, as we hear in the liturgy “those seen and unseen that we enjoy” Or do we take the life he gave us as an accident of nature, and the eternal life he obtained with his blood for our sake as a mere fable?*
- ◆ Leading up to and throughout the Divine Liturgy all must reflect and ponder upon the marvelous plan of salvation and with utter reverence we must then fervently thank the Lord and prepare to receive Him.

God the Father

- ◆ The anaphora of CHR & BAS is addressed to God the Father. While it is prayed by the presiding celebrant by virtue of ordination, it is not the individual's prayer but rather the prayer of the whole church. The celebrant offers it on behalf of, for and with the people. For this precise reason the Ecumenical Patriarchate long ago ordered that it be said aloud at every Eucharistic celebration so that

the people may hear and participate, that they may be inspired and guided by it – Fr Calivas, Aspects of Orthodox Worship, 214

- ✦ It is a single prayer and not a series of prayers and hymns.+6 This unity or singleness is key to understanding and appreciating its purpose, essence, and power to inform and transform God's faithful people.
- ✦ This awesome and powerful prayer recognizes God in what He Is and for what He Is. God is addressed not as a “monad” but as a “triad”, thus thanks are also given to His Only Begotten Son and to His Holy Spirit.

Holy, Holy, Holy

- ✦ The words “singing, exclaiming, proclaiming” mean that we should join the angels of God in singing to His glory. The angels surround the throne of God and minister to His Will. The Old Testament book of Isaiah tells us the actual words of the angels that glorify God. Is in these same words that we are invited to join the angelic choirs in praise of God
- ✦ “Holy, Holy, Holy, Lord of angelic hosts, Heaven and earth are filled with Your glory. Hosanna in the Highest” Isaiah 6:3 This is also the hymn that the people sang when they welcomed the King of Heaven (Jesus Christ) into the city of Jerusalem on His way to be sacrificed
- ✦ Hosanna is a Hebrew word which means “God save” or “help.” Hosanna in the Highest means that we offer our hymn to the highest dwelling place where God abides.
- ✦ Heaven and earth are now united together! Angels along with the faithful men women and children chant now together in one voice in honor of the second person of the Trinity, the Godman and His victory!
- ✦ The hymn that is sung is called triumphal because it praises our Lord and savior Jesus Christ's victory over death and the devil.

The Anamnesis/The Remembrance

- ✦ From the proclamation of God's holiness, the anaphora proceeds to this next focus, the remembrance, which in CHR consists of the following areas:
- ✦ (a) God’s providential saving activity (*you so loved your world that you gave your only begotten son that whoever believes in him should not perish but have eternal life*)

- ◆ (b) the actions of the Lord at the mystical supper (*when he had come and fulfilled for our sake the entire plan of salvation, on the night in which he was delivered up, or rather when he delivered himself up for the life of the world, he took bread...*)
- ◆ (c) the saving command “Do this” by which the Eucharist was established (*remembering, therefore, this saving command*)
- ◆ (d) the words of institution, the words spoken by the Lord over the bread and the cup at the Last Supper (*He took bread in His Holy, Pure, and Blameless Hands, and gave thanks... He gave it to His holy disciples and apostles saying...*)

Leavened or Unleavened Bread???

- ◆ What kind of bread did the Lord take in his hands this is the question that has been at the very core of eucharistic dialogue especially between East and West. Roman Catholicism state unleavened, while eastern orthodox say leavened.
- ◆ What does the evidence say? As this is of great importance
- ◆ all the New Testament sources use the word “artos” a term normally associated with leavened bread. The Lord did not use “azyma” A term associated with unleavened bread.
- ◆ The universal use of leaven bread in the first centuries of the church is amply documented by the ecclesiastical writers. They all systematically and without exception use the term “artos” for the divine Eucharist.
- ◆ The Orthodox Church insisted on the use of leaven bread, against the introduction of unleavened bread in the Western Church (Catholicism). According to Saint nicodemos, the western church was using leaven bread until the year 1053 when “Leo IX became the first inventor of unleavened wafers” Rudder pg. 129
- ◆ The following Patriarchal Encyclical of 1895 – A reply to the Papal Encyclical of Pope Leo XIII - sums of the Orthodox position:
- ◆ *“The one holy, Catholic and Apostolic Church of the seven ecumenical councils, according to the example of our savior, celebrated the divine Eucharist for more than 1000 years throughout the east and West with leavened bread, as the truth loving papal theologians themselves also bear witness; but the papal church from the 11th century made an innovation also in the sacrament of the divine Eucharist by introducing unleavened bread.”*

The words of our Lord

- ◆ The main celebrant now uses Christ's own words for the most inspiring moment of the Divine Liturgy
- ◆ side note...This is an excellent time for all to focus on the icon of the mystical supper which is usually located above the gates of the royal doors
- ◆ We are to remember that the institution of the holy Eucharist is the greatest testimony to God's supreme love.
- ◆ We, too, are now present at the Mystical Supper and must be attentive participants in the sacred events taking place.

Your own of Your own

- ◆ The very words of our Lord and savior that were pronounced by him are the same words that are used at the highest point of the divine service. They once again reveal his infinite love for creation, which led him to be sacrificed for our sake and salvation.
- ◆ As we then remember the Lord's words and bring to mind his cross, tomb, resurrection, ascension and 2nd coming we integrate our own offering- which is what Christ himself offered at the mystical supper. The celebrant exclaims...
- ◆ **“Your own of Your own we offer to You in all and for all.”**
- ◆ This means that we offer to God which he has given us just as he offered them at the mystical supper, we do this in thanksgiving for all his divine gifts.
- ◆ It is ironic that we really have nothing and all we have to offer to God is God Himself - our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.
- ◆ After which the priest states, “thine Own of thine own we offer unto thee in behalf of all and for all.” During which time the priest lifts up the Eucharistic gifts and elevates them towards the heaven. It is the sign that the faithful Christians have been exalted together with their Lord into the Kingdom of God. The ages past and the ages still to come are brought into unity. The night, the supper, the cross, the tomb, the resurrection all merge together in the Eucharistic moment of the Liturgy. Man is with God in a holy communion which is not of this world.
- ◆ “It was by eating that man got into trouble in the garden of Eden. And it is by eating that salvation comes” Fr Anthony Coniaris